

**First Congregational Church of Los Angeles**  
**Pentecost 14**  
*Another Kind of Freedom ~ Understanding Community*  
**30 August 2026**

**Preaching: ML**

**Worship Leading: LVF & TBD**

**STRIPS OF PAPER IN PROGRAM FOR PRAYERS**

**Organ Prelude-Concert**

[CB back, but joined in Prelude Concert by Guest Organist Emmanuel Duperrey]

[Guest Saxophonist Jordan Leicht]

Program by Guest Organist Emmanuel Duperrey to be supplied

Emmanuel Duperrey, *Guest Organist*

Hymn Improvisation

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

**Chiming of the Hour**

**[Laura and ... center chancel]**

**Welcome**

**LVF**

**Words of Gathering**

**LVF & ...**

Listen: the fingerprints, footprints, and soul-prints of the Creator, have put their mark on us as we begin our time together on this day...

As children of the Most High, we affirm that life is a journey of faith:

*A journey to the heart of life, to the center of God's awesome creation,  
to the intersection of holy moments.*

As siblings of the Christ, we affirm that life is a journey of faith:

*A journey to the edge of life, to the boundaries of the human condition,  
to the intersection of holy moments.*

As children and siblings, we affirm that life is a journey of faith:

*A journey to the in-between places of life: the encounters, confrontations,  
serendipities, the intersection of holy moments.*

As a people gathered from near and far, we affirm that life is a journey of faith:

*Let us begin anew, here and now, in this place and time. Let this be an*

*intersection of holy moments. Let this be our act of thankfulness  
for the grace and goodness of this life together!*

May it be so.

*May it be so for all of us!*

*Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering*

**\*Hymn of Gathering**

**[Laura center chancel]**

**\*Prayer of Awareness**

**LVF**

Creator God, maker of dancing stars and moonlit summer nights,  
sender of gentle breezes and swirling winds,  
finder of lost opportunities and mender of broken dreams,  
you bless our lives with holy possibilities, beckoning us on a journey with you –  
and your still-speaking voice.

Compassionate God, you know us inside and out.  
When our hearts sigh with grief too large to carry—you are there.  
When our tears flow like angry streams—you are there.  
When doubts snare us like a trap—you are there.  
When hope dwindles to a thin strand—you are there.

Gracious and Loving God, you know our comings and our goings.  
You know when we fail and when we find success.  
You know the deepest longings of our hearts.  
Through it all, your love surrounds us, embraces us, sustains us,  
and opens our eyes to the wondrous possibilities you place before us.

*In the promise of this moment, Holy One, speak to us anew  
that we might capture the vision for living fully  
as your children, whose love and strength,  
will help nurture freedom and community in our world.  
Amen and Amen.*

**\*Introit**

Won't You Be My Neighbor? Fred Rogers, arr. Katelyn Dietz  
Katelyn Dietz & Molly Pease, *Soloists*, Jordan Leicht, *Saxophone*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Rhythm Section*

**[... to lectern]**

**\*The Lord's Prayer**

**Let us pray together this Lord's Prayer, adapted by enfleshed...**

*Weaver of Life, Ancient and Unfolding,  
How sacred is your Presence!  
We lean on your guidance.  
We seek your love.  
We open to your transformation.  
Provide us bread in body and spirit  
to sustain us in faith and solidarity.  
Companion us with grace  
as we seek to live lives of forgiveness and compassion,  
repair and accountability.  
We remember those who have supported us  
as we seek to support others  
in all the mess and glory of this human journey.  
Guard our minds and hearts from the temptation of domination  
and turn our loyalty away from the systems of evil.  
For the whole cosmos hums with your wisdom.  
Everything that lives, returns to your care.  
Our thanks and honor to you,  
Gracious Web of Existence,  
Our Source and our Home.  
Amen and Amen.*

[enfleshed]

**\*Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,  
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.  
World without end, Amen, Amen.

**[Laura center chancel]**

**\*Passing of the Peace**

**LVF**

Pause . . .  
for a brief moment and cease your frantic pace  
Imagine . . .  
the possibilities for being your authentic self  
Create . . .  
a space for your Muse—be open to discovering your creativity  
Become . . .  
a catalyst—dance, sculpt, sing, play your holy art for the world.

And as you pause, imagine, create, and become more of who you truly are...

May the peace of God be with you.  
*And also with you!*

*You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow*

*Please be seated*

[... to lectern]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

*from Psalm 148*

**Let us together share this beautiful rendering of Psalm 148 by Nan Merrill...**

Let all people praise the Beloved,  
who is exalted in heaven  
and on earth;  
whose glory is above  
heaven and earth.

For all are to be called friends,  
companions to the true Friend,  
giving their lives joyfully  
as co-creators and  
people of peace.

*Praise to the Blessed One,  
the very Breath of our breath,  
the very Heart of our heart.*

For this chorus of the ancients...  
*Thanks be to God!*

**[Christoph transition Laura center chancel]**

**Prayers with the People**

**LVF**

**Invitation to Silence and Prayer**

As we come to this time of silence and prayer,  
listen now to these words from Joyce Rupp,  
as our invitation to open our hearts, our minds,  
and our bodies, to the Holy One...  
*wait three seconds*

You are the One sent to free us  
from inner and outer oppression,  
to liberate us from our illusions  
and anything taking us from you,  
assisting us to recover our ability  
to be people of loving kindness.  
You have shown us the clear way  
and have loved us back into life.

And you will wait  
for as long as it takes  
for us to accept your gift of freedom.

- Joyce Rupp

Invitation to write prayers and bring them forward to the bowl and to light candles.  
Online folx, please email yours to [prayers@fccla.org](mailto:prayers@fccla.org)

Let us now be in silence, together...

[Laura to seat]

*Silence*

[Christoph transition out of silence and play as people come forward to offer Prayers]

[Laura center chancel when all are seated]

**Prayer of Our Hearts**

*from Psalm 119*

LVF

Holy One, you whisper our names, inviting us to dream, to wonder,  
to be filled with awe as their holy possibilities appear on our horizons.  
*In this sacred time and space, we wonder, individually and collectively,  
if this time of holy possibility is truly meant for each one of us.*

Trusting in the wisdom of the ancestors who have gone before us,  
this morning we open our minds, our hearts, and our bodies to you, Holy One,  
You who is here and available for each one of us, for all of us,  
and in this time, anything is possible.

*All of us?*

Yes, all of us, and as we breathe together, may we begin to expect the impossible.

*Are we sure it is for all of us? The proud and the strong, the lost and the searching,  
the joyous and the sad?*

Absolutely! Breathe in together and begin to experience the impossible.

*All of us...word-arrangers and finger-painters, rope-jumpers and slow-walkers, belly-laughers and soul-singers?*

Yes! Breathe in together and begin to live the impossible.

Here and now, O Holy One, break into our experience  
and call us into the heart of life on this journey,  
we are privileged to share.

May it be so.

*May it be so for all of us,  
gathered here in this time and place, together.*

**[Christoph transition for Laude]**

**Meditation Anthem**      *Precious Lord, Take My Hand*      Thomas Dorsey, arr. Arnold Sevier  
Laude, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

**[Christoph transition Michael to pulpit]**

**Sermon**      *Understanding Community*      **ML**  
**Music for Reflection**      *For Solo Saxophone*      Jordan Leicht  
Jordan Leicht, *Saxophone*

**[Christoph transition ... to lectern]**

**Invitation to Generosity**

It has been an amazing morning at First Church and we are grateful to our entire staff and our guest musicians - for all the time, energy, and creativity - that was woven together in order to make this dream possible.

The dreams and visions that we have for this place we all call home, are continually blessing our times together, even as we continue stretching toward that, which is yet to come.

We invite you to be part of what is happening in this place, through the giving of your time, your skills, your talent, your creativity, your energy - and yes - your financial resources. We depend on all the gifts you bring to this sacred dream and we are thankful for who the Holy is gathering, to do this work together.

You may give by using the QR Code in your programs and appearing now on your screens if you are watching online. Also, those that greeted you on the way in will have baskets on your way out or to Coffee Hour, and there's a box at the back of the sanctuary. You can also give anytime, by visiting [fccla.org/give](http://fccla.org/give).

**Offertory Anthem**      Take 5      Paul Desmond/Douglas E. Wagner  
Bell Choir, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Director*, Jordan Leicht, *Alto Saxophone*

**[All turn towards altar]**

**\*Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,  
let the Creator's praise arise!  
Alleluia! Alleluia!  
Your name shall sound and praises soar  
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!  
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!  
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

**[... to lectern]**

**\*Offering Prayer**

Good and Gracious God, we are overflowing with gratitude  
for the ways in which you continue to co-create the present,  
and the future, with us.

We ask that you help us discern and come to know -  
all that is happening around us, among us, and within us,  
as we journey together, guided by your light and your love.

May it be so.  
*May it be so for all of us!*  
*Amen and Amen!*

*Please be seated*

**[Michael & Laura center chancel]**

**Life at First Church**

**LVF & ML**

**Words of Blessing**

**ML**

**Please join me now for these Words of Blessing...**

That when freedom comes  
we will open our eyes  
to see it.

*That when freedom shows up  
we will let ourselves  
be overcome  
not by fear  
but by the love  
it bears.*

That when freedom shines  
we will bring it  
with us  
*all the way*  
all the way  
*all the way home.* [adapt/jrichardson]

May it be so.

***May it be so for all of us!***

**Choral Response**    *When the Saints Go Marching In*    Traditional African-American Spiritual  
Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

**\*Hymn for the Journey**

**[Laura center chancel]**

**Postlude**        Davy Jones plays his Organ (Hans Zimmer, adapted for Organ by C. Bull)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

**Inside The Music**